Taungoo's walled city provides a glimpse into the political notions of Myanmar's 'undecided' voters and the institutions with which their lives are tightly interwoven.[12] The family lives in a compound with two houses, one occupied by the patriarch and matriarch of the family, and the other by one of their sons and his family. The patriarch of the family, now sixty-seven, tills a rice paddy nearby with the help of two oxen that occupy their own corner of the family compound. Meanwhile, their five children — who range in age from their early forties to their twenty-four-year-old daughter — work in local rice, durian, and betel nut plantations, as well as in trade and hospitality.

Financially, the national-level economic reforms of recent years have had a noticeable impact on the family's economic fortunes. The largest family incomes are earned by two children — one who works in a local agricultural trade company, and the other in a restaurant adjacent to one of Taungoo's mid-range hotels, a job she received through the patronage of a prominent local Shan businessman. On a national level, both of these industries — agricultural trade and the services sector — have grown substantially since the commencement of political and economic reforms in 2011. Life is easier than it was five years ago. The family has more income and substantially improved freedom of movement than in the early 2000s. They refer explicitly to national-level reforms when explaining the improvement in their lives, and attribute changes directly to former President Thein Sein; however, they are quick to add that they also admire Aung San Suu Kyi.

Although they acknowledge the impact of national-level reforms on their lives, the family members see themselves and their village as largely self-reliant. When asked about the people or organizations that provide them with assistance, the main social institution they mention is the monastery a few hundred metres down a dusty lane. The family makes substantial donations to support the initiatives of the local monks — including financial and in-kind contributions of both food and their own time as regular volunteers for various monastic projects. They contribute daily to the alms bowls of the local monks, and visit the pagoda nearby for prayer at least twice a week. They estimate that they donate an average of 5000 kyat (US$3.88) to the monastery per month. In a context where the wage for someone employed on a plantation, in a stone quarry, or as a driver is around 50,000 (US$38) kyat a month, this is a substantial proportion of income but is consistent with a pattern across Myanmar,